



Paul Kagame

(kah-GAH-may)

President

Republic of Rwanda

Addressed as: **Your Excellency** | Office held since: **April 2000**

Paul Kagame is a guarded, exacting leader whose quest for Rwandan self-reliance colors his unapologetic approach to development, security, and statecraft.

▣ Development Mindset

Kagame is insistent about moving Rwanda to a private-sector-led economic model, shifting away from donor dependency and subsistence livelihoods. In his most recent New Year's address, he stated that "we cannot count on anyone else to finance our development and well-being."

▣ Defensive Measures

Kagame is fixated on securing Rwanda's borders permanently against what he perceives as external threats, routinely dismissing international condemnation for violations of Congolese territorial sovereignty and human rights abuses by proxy forces.

Kagame's strong sense of purpose often leads him to reject international criticism ("we are not afraid of anything. We are not afraid of sanctions, we are not afraid of any so-called consequences") and disregard compliments ("we don't do anything for praise, we don't need anybody's praise").

WHY THEY MATTER

Kagame is invested in building Rwanda's energy sector from near-zero and has extended Rwanda's military reach to protect energy infrastructure in neighboring countries.

▣ Domestic Energy Ambitions

Kagame views current global energy demands as an opportunity to position Rwanda as a regional hub. He signed an MOU with Kenya to use the port of Mombasa, pressed TotalEnergies to diversify its local operations, and backed the commercialization of Lake Kivu's biomethane gas reserves.

▣ Regional Security Deployments

Kagame has deployed the country's disciplined military as a "security exporter" to combat insecurity in the Central African Republic and protect multi-billion-dollar international oil and gas assets in Mozambique.

At the Nuclear Energy Innovation Summit in Kigali in May 2026, Kagame underscored that there is "a growing consensus that the future of our economies depends on how quickly we solve the energy challenge."

MEETING WITH THEM

Kagame is a close listener who values substance and sincerity. He shares his warm, personal side when he is satisfied with the discussion or turns cold and confrontational when he is not.

▣ **Connecting Through Personal Stories**

Kagame is often intense in meetings, but becomes softer and more approachable when counterparts show that they understand his perspective and are prepared to work in common cause. He starts to share his dry sense of humor, even recounting personal stories about his life and family.

▣ **Challenging by Pointed Questions**

Kagame is quick to contest his interlocutor's position and premise, especially if it impugns Rwanda's reputation. He becomes stiffer in demeanor, asking "what is the logic?", "how has this become Rwanda's problem?", and "who defines the values?" On occasion, he has abruptly left meetings when he feels he is being treated disrespectfully.

Kagame's trust is hard-earned, and it often takes several engagements to develop a rapport. To that end, he often relies on his close advisors and key ministers to make decisions on their own or present recommendations to him about a specific action item.

ON THEIR MIND

▣ **East Congo Peace Process**

Implementation of the Washington Accords between Rwanda and Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) continues to be marred by disagreements. In late May, the DRC claimed the Democratic Forces for the Liberation of Rwanda (FDLR), a rebel force linked to the 1994 Genocide, signed a protocol committing to disarmament. Rwanda dismissed it as a delaying tactic, saying the peace deal requires FDLR's neutralization.

▣ **Ebola Containment Efforts**

Rwanda is strengthening health screening at border crossings, expanding disease surveillance and preparing rapid response teams to investigate suspected cases to prevent the disease's spread from neighboring DRC .

▣ **Aston Villa Deal**

The English Premier League football team in July reached an agreement with Visit Rwanda as the club's new front-of-shirt sponsor. Visit Rwanda's sports sponsorship initiative has come under fire for its human rights record, but its partnerships still include Paris Saint-Germain and Atletico Madrid; its shirt sleeve deal with Arsenal recently concluded after eight years.

▣ **IMF Credit Facility**

The IMF in June approved Rwanda's request for a new \$250 million, 38-month extended credit facility to help it deal with tighter global financial conditions, while protecting social and development spending.

NETWORK

Kagame navigates contentious but pragmatic relationships with several Western governments and pursues strategic ties with most regional neighbors, especially Mozambique.

Kagame acknowledges the importance of engaging with global powers regarding security and investment, but he has lashed out at the United States and European Union and even severed ties in the case of Belgium when he views action as one-sided or punitive. His partnerships with most African counterparts, including Mozambican leader President Daniel Chapo, are more constructive.

Kagame's inner circle is dominated by military figures who served with him during the Rwandan Patriotic Front (RPF) campaign in the 1990s and a growing number of younger technocrats who have risen under his tutelage during the past three decades.

Kagame remains close to many of his RPF compatriots, such as senior advisor James Kabarebe, although he has fallen out with others who have become critics and dissidents. At the same time, Kagame has also promoted several younger technocrats, including Minister of Health Sabin Nsanzimana and Minister of ICT and Innovation Paula Ingabire who have emerged as prominent leaders in their own right.

CONTROVERSIES

While Kagame attracts a large number of admirers for Rwanda's transformational development, he also faces detractors who point to support for rebels in neighboring DRC and relatively closed political space.

▣ Conflict in Eastern Congo

While Kagame acknowledges his forces have adopted "defensive measures," the UN Group of Experts in 2025 stated that Rwanda exercised "significant command and control" over the M23 rebellion, supplied advanced weapons, and maintained thousands of soldiers in eastern Congo. There are also allegations that minerals from M23-controlled areas, especially coltan, have been smuggled into Rwanda at an "unprecedented" scale.

▣ Curbs on Political Pluralism

Kagame's critics often denounce what they view as his authoritarian rule, pointing to detention of journalists, limits on freedom of speech, and the banning of opposition candidates from running for office; in July 2024, Kagame received 99.18 percent of the official vote in an election where eight other prospective candidates were not cleared to run.



CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- ▣ **President**, Republic of Rwanda (2000 to present)
- ▣ **Vice President and Minister of Defense**, Republic of Rwanda (1994 to 2000)
- ▣ **Commander**, Rwandan Patriotic Front (1990 to 1994)
- ▣ **Director of Military Intelligence**, Ugandan National Resistance Army (1986 to 1990)
- ▣ **Rebel Commander**, Ugandan National Resistance Movement (1981 to 1986)

BIO

Kagame's personal story is inseparable from Rwanda's national trauma—a refugee child who became a guerrilla intelligence officer, then a commanding general, then the leader who stopped a genocide. Born on October 23, 1957, he fled Rwanda with his family when he was two, settling in the Nshungerezi refugee camp. He joined the Ugandan bush war under Yoweri Museveni, rising to head military intelligence and later assumed command of his Rwandan rebel forces to challenge the genocidal regime in Kigali.

▣ **Global Statesman**

Kagame has positioned Rwanda as a voice in global governance well beyond its size. He co-chairs the AI for Good Global Commission, led the African Union as chairman in 2018, and has been a prominent advocate for reforming international development assistance. He told an African audience that being "left more to its own devices was not necessarily a bad outcome" for the continent.

▣ **Global Sports Fan**

Kagame is a devoted Arsenal supporter and celebrated when the team finally won its first Premier League championship in 22 years in mid-2026. He plays tennis regularly, won the amateur doubles at the 2007 BCR Open, built the BK Arena in Kigali for the Basketball Africa League, and hosted the UCI Road World Championships in 2025.

Kagame married Jeannette Nyiramongi in Kampala in 1989; they have four children. He drove them to school even as vice president, and his eldest once confronted him about not spending enough time at home. He is Catholic by upbringing but describes himself as "minimally religious." He speaks Kinyarwanda, English, and Swahili fluently, and French "when I want."